A LOCAL ENVIRONMENTAL TRADEOFF

Let It Rot

What if fall cleanup could create something useful for our parks, gardens, and neighborhoods?

THE IDEA

Each autumn, towns have to deal with piles of fallen leaves. Instead of treating them as trash, communities could collect them, compost them, and use the finished compost in parks and gardens. The idea is to test whether this is a better use of local resources before making it a permanent program.

THE PROPOSITION

Establish a One-Season Municipal Leaf-Composting Pilot

THE BALLOT QUESTION

Shall a one-fall-season leaf-composting pilot be established using an existing public site or approved local composting facility; collect leaves at designated drop-off points or existing yard-waste collection events; track the tonnage collected and full program costs; use finished compost in public landscaping where appropriate; and publish results before deciding whether to continue the program?

If you vote YES, here's what it could look like

For fall 2027, the proposal would launch a one-season pilot in 200 towns and townships across the United States where leaf composting makes sense. Each participating town would use a suitable existing site or approved facility when possible, set up drop-off points or work with its current yard-waste collection, and track how many tons of leaves are collected and what the program costs. After the season, towns would publish the results and compare the costs and benefits before deciding whether to continue. The goal is to test the idea—not assume every town will get the same results.

What's the deal?

Compost can improve soil, help it hold water, and reduce erosion. Collecting leaves for composting can also keep some yard waste out of landfills. But the town would need staff, vehicles, fuel, a place to process the leaves, and a plan for using the finished compost. Residents might have to use drop-off points or follow new collection rules. The proposal is a pilot for the fall 2027 season in 200 towns/townships across the US where it is relevant. The costs and tons would depend on each town's current equipment, available space, and percent participating. As these will vary from town to town, these variances are expected to be tracked and published. In economic terms, the pilot tests whether the benefits are worth the opportunity cost of using public money and staff time for this program instead of something else.

The best case for YES

Leaves are a seasonal resource, not just something to get rid of. The New York State Department of Environmental Conservation says leaves can be composted or used as mulch, and notes that some communities collect leaves or let residents bring them to a central composting site. Compost can enrich

The best case for NO

A new leaf program could significantly raise costs for taxpayers. Public works staff may face more work during an already busy season, and residents could come to expect a service that the town cannot afford to keep running. Some towns may not have enough land for a composting site or the trucks and equipment needed to

composting site. Compost can enrich soil, and shredding leaves can reduce their volume. A pilot could turn some yard waste into a useful product for parks and gardens instead of paying to dispose of it. Tracking tons collected, costs, and participation would help towns compare the benefits with the costs and decide whether the program is worth continuing.

the trucks and equipment needed to collect and move leaves. Buying equipment or building a facility could make the program unrealistic for smaller towns. There is also an opportunity cost: money spent on leaf composting may have to come out of another service, such as road repairs, parks, or a different environmental program. If participation is low or hauling is expensive, the marginal costs could outweigh the benefits. These are risks to test, not proof that every town would lose money.

Why isn’t this already happening?

Some towns already mulch leaves, collect yard waste, or use a composting facility, so a new program may not add much. Residents may also prefer to stick with the town’s current system because they know how it works and do not want new rules. A change takes staff time, equipment, space, and planning, and the benefits may be hard to measure. For example, a town would need to compare its current disposal costs with the full cost of collecting and composting leaves, while also tracking how much waste is diverted and how much compost is used. Without that comparison, it is hard to know whether the change is worth the opportunity cost or whether the same money could do more good elsewhere.

Where is the body buried?

The weakest assumption is that enough residents will participate to make the program worth its cost. Taxpayers could lose out if collection and facility costs rise, while public works staff take on more work. The biggest unknowns are the number of tons collected, participation rates, and the cost per ton. Towns without space or equipment may not be able to take part. Even if composting creates environmental benefits, the opportunity cost

matters: money used here cannot be spent on another public service. The pilot needs clear measures to show whether its benefits outweigh its costs.

Sources and further reading

- U.S. Environmental Protection Agency — Composting: explains composting, organic waste diversion, and environmental benefits